

Learn HTML

Lesson 2: Text Formatting Tags

Text Formatting Tags – Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **HTML heading tags** (`<h1>`–`<h6>`) – define hierarchical titles and improve SEO.
2. **Paragraph tag** (`<p>`) – creates a block of text with automatic vertical spacing.
3. **Bold and italics** (`<strong>`, `<b>`, `<em>`, `<i>`) – convey emphasis and importance.
4. **Line break tag** (`<br>`) – forces a single line break without starting a new paragraph.
5. **Semantic vs. presentational markup** – prefer `<strong>`/`<em>` for meaning; use `<b>`/`<i>` only for visual styling when semantics aren't needed.

Summary

Text formatting tags are the building blocks for structuring and styling content on the web. Headings (`<h1>`–`<h6>`) establish a clear hierarchy, allowing both users and search engines to understand the organization of a page. Paragraphs (`<p>`) group related sentences together, automatically adding spacing before and after the block, which keeps the layout readable.

For emphasis, HTML provides two pairs of tags. `<strong>` and `<em>` carry semantic meaning—indicating strong importance and stress, respectively—while `<b>` and `<i>` simply change the visual appearance to bold or italic without implying importance. The line break tag (`<br>`) inserts a single line break within a block of text, useful for addresses, poetry, or when you need precise control over line spacing without creating a new paragraph.

Choosing the right tag improves accessibility (screen readers announce `<strong>` and `<em>` differently), SEO (search engines treat headings as key topics), and maintainability (semantic markup is easier to style with CSS).

Important Points

- **Headings:** Only one `<h1>` per page is recommended; use `<h2>`–`<h6>` for sub sections.
- **Paragraphs:** `<p>` automatically adds margin; avoid using multiple `<br>` tags to simulate spacing.
 - **Bold vs. Strong:**
 - `<strong>` – semantic emphasis (important).
 - `<b>` – visual bolding only.
 - **Italics vs. Emphasis:**
 - `<em>` – semantic emphasis (stress).
 - `<i>` – visual italics (e.g., technical terms).
- **Line Break** (`<br>`): Use sparingly; prefer CSS (`margin`, `padding`) for spacing.

- **Accessibility:** Screen readers announce `<strong>` and `<em>` with emphasis; `<b>`/`<i>` are read as normal text.

Examples

Example 1 – Basic Document Structure

```
``html
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <title>Formatting Demo</title>
</head>
<body>
<h1>Welcome to My Blog</h1>
<h2>Today's Topic: HTML Basics</h2>
<p>This paragraph introduces the <strong>key concepts</strong> of HTML.
  Notice how <em>emphasis</em> is used to stress important words.</p>
<p>Here is a line break example:<br>
  First line of the address.<br>
  Second line of the address.</p>
</body>
</html>
``
```

Explanation:

- `<h1>` and `<h2>` create a clear hierarchy.
- `<strong>` and `<em>` add semantic emphasis.
- `<br>` forces line breaks inside the second paragraph without starting a new `<p>` block.

Example 2 – Using `<b>` and `<i>` for visual styling

```
``html
<p>Our new product, <b>SuperWidget 3000</b>, is now available!
  It features an <i>innovative</i> design that saves space.</p>
``
```

Explanation:

- `<b>` makes “SuperWidget 3000” bold for visual impact, but it doesn’t imply importance to assistive tech.
- `<i>` italicizes “innovative” for stylistic effect (e.g., a product name).

Quick Review

1. **Which heading tag should be used for the main title of a page?**
2. **What is the difference between `<strong>` and `<b>`?**

3. **When would you choose `<br>` over creating a new `<p>` element?**
4. **Name two benefits of using semantic tags like `<em>` instead of purely visual tags.**
5. **How does the browser treat multiple consecutive `<br>` tags?**

Further Reading

- **HTML Semantic Elements** – `<article>`, `<section>`, `<nav>`, `<aside>`
- **CSS for Text Styling** – `font-weight`, `font-style`, `text-decoration`, and spacing utilities
- **Accessibility Guidelines** – ARIA roles, screen reader best practices, WCAG text contrast rules
- **HTML5 Document Outline** – how headings interact with the outline algorithm
- **Responsive Typography** – using `rem`, `clamp()`, and media queries for scalable text
